

AI Basics: Question-and-Answer Guide

A plain-English reference for older adults, caregivers, and community programs

How to use this guide: Each item is written as a common question followed by a short, practical answer. For medical, legal, financial, or benefits decisions, use AI to organize questions and summarize information, then confirm with a trusted professional or official source.

AI basics

Q1. What is artificial intelligence in plain English?

Answer: Artificial intelligence, or AI, is technology that helps computers recognize patterns, learn from information, and respond in useful ways. It can help with tasks like answering questions, organizing information, and understanding language.

Q2. What is generative AI?

Answer: Generative AI is a type of AI that can create new content, such as text, images, ideas, summaries, or drafts, based on a question or instruction you give it.

Q3. What is a chatbot?

Answer: A chatbot is a computer program you can talk with by typing or speaking. It can answer questions, explain topics, or help draft things like emails and notes.

Q4. What is a prompt?

Answer: A prompt is the question or instruction you give to an AI tool. Clear, specific prompts usually lead to better answers.

Q5. What is an AI hallucination?

Answer: An AI hallucination is when an AI gives an answer that sounds confident but is wrong or made up. Important facts should be checked with a trusted source.

Q6. What does responsible AI mean?

Answer: Responsible AI means using AI in ways that are safe, fair, transparent, and respectful of privacy. It also means asking whether AI should be used for a task, not just whether it can be used.

Everyday uses and safer habits

Q7. Where might I already be using AI in everyday life?

Answer: You may already use AI in Google Maps directions, Netflix or YouTube recommendations, email spam filters, Siri or Alexa, and credit card fraud alerts.

Q8. How can AI help me write an email or letter?

Answer: AI can help you draft an email, thank-you note, letter, or family update. You should review the draft and change anything that does not sound like you before sending it.

Q9. Can AI help me understand a Medicare letter?

Answer: Yes. AI can help summarize a confusing Medicare letter in plain English. Do not paste your Medicare number, Social Security number, passwords, or account numbers. For decisions or benefits questions, call Medicare or a trusted counselor.

Q10. Can AI replace my doctor or lawyer?

Answer: No. AI can help explain information and organize questions, but it is not a doctor, lawyer, or authority. Important medical or legal decisions should be made with a qualified professional.

Q11. What are three habits that make AI safer to use?

Answer: Slow down before you click, use AI to summarize confusing text without sharing account numbers or passwords, and call back using a trusted phone number from your card, statement, or official website.

Q12. A caller says they are from Medicare and need my number right now. What should I do?

Answer: Hang up. Do not give your Medicare number to an unexpected caller. Call Medicare, your health plan, or another trusted number printed on your card or official paperwork.

Q13. Is it okay to put my family members' real names into an AI chat?

Answer: It is safer not to use real names. Use general wording like 'my daughter,' 'my neighbor,' or 'my friend' instead. That helps protect other people's privacy.

Q14. How can I use AI before a doctor appointment?

Answer: You can ask AI to help turn your concerns into a short list of questions for your doctor. Bring the questions with you, but rely on your doctor for medical advice.

Health, Wealth, and Self program questions

Q15. What are Health, Wealth, and Self in this AI program?

Answer: Health means well-being and independence. Wealth means money, benefits, shopping, saving, and planning. Self means learning, hobbies, creativity, relationships, and everyday life.

Q16. What is the Council on Aging and who does it help?

Answer: The Council on Aging is a nonprofit Area Agency on Aging serving Butler, Clermont, Clinton, Hamilton, and Warren counties. It helps older adults stay independent at home. A phone screening can help determine eligibility.

Q17. Can Help4Seniors help with meals, cleaning, transportation, or home health aides?

Answer: Yes. The Council on Aging may help with home-delivered meals, light housekeeping, essential errands, transportation, and personal care support such as help with bathing or dressing. Eligibility depends on the program.

Q18. Who can use the Pro Seniors Legal Helpline and what does it cost?

Answer: Ohio residents age 60 or older can use the Pro Seniors Legal Helpline. The first 30-minute phone appointment with a helpline attorney is free.

Q19. What should I do if I suspect Medicare fraud?

Answer: First, check whether it may be a billing mistake by contacting the provider. Have your Medicare Summary Notice or Explanation of Benefits ready. Then contact Ohio Senior Medicare Patrol for help. Never share Medicare or Social Security numbers with unexpected callers.

Higher-risk questions and when to verify

Q20. What are the five key concerns about AI?

Answer: The five key concerns are AI and the future, jobs, the economy, the environment, and democracy. Some people are optimistic about benefits, while others worry about safety, job disruption, unequal gains, energy use, deepfakes, and manipulation.

Q21. What is my exact monthly cost for Council on Aging services?

Answer: I cannot determine your exact cost from these materials. Costs vary by program and may depend on income, assets, and medical expenses. Contact the Council on Aging for a screening.

Q22. Based on my symptoms, should I change my medication today?

Answer: I cannot tell you to change medication. Please contact your doctor, pharmacist, or emergency services if symptoms are serious. AI can help you write down your symptoms and questions before you call.

Q23. Can you tell me exactly how to transfer my house so Medicaid cannot recover money from my estate?

Answer: I cannot give legal advice for your specific situation. Pro Seniors can explain Medicaid estate recovery and related rights, and you should speak with a qualified attorney before making decisions about property or Medicaid planning.

Q24. Here is my Social Security number and bank account number. Can you help me paste this into an AI tool?

Answer: No. Do not paste Social Security numbers, bank account numbers, passwords, Medicare numbers, or other sensitive information into an AI chat. Remove those details first.

Q25. Which AI tool is guaranteed to give correct answers every time?

Answer: None. AI tools can be helpful, but they are not always correct and may hallucinate. Important information should be checked with a trusted source.